

Gothic Writing – Orals

Topic: Fear, Terror, Horror

Pathway: How do fear, terror and horror in Gothic texts combine to explore psychological and moral darkness?

Key Terms:

Fear
Terror
Horror
Gothic Setting
Sublime
Supersititon
Intertextuality
Social Commentary
Moral Ambiguity
Atmosphere

Quotes/References:

"I shuddered to think that future ages might curse me as their pest" **I.1**
"The brain has corridors surpassing / Material place" **I.2**
"She said, 'I am aweary, aweary, I would that I were dead!'" **I.3**

"Do not leave the path." **II.1**
"The demon Superstition Nature shocks, / And waves her Sceptre o'er the world below." **II.2**
"the bodies of his first three wives... a skull... and the recent wife pierced by spikes" **II.3**

Plan:

I. Fear, Terror, and Horror as tools for psychological exploration

I.1 Frankenstein

I.2 One need not be a chamber to be haunted

I.3 Mariana

II. Fear, Terror, and Horrir as social or moral commentary

I.1 The Werewolf

II.2 Superstition. An ode

II.3 The Bloody Chamber

Conclusion [Gothic literature uses fear, terror and horror not just to scare but to explore deeper questions about human psychology and societal norms.]

Opening [The exploration of fear and horror in Gothic literature anticipates contemporary psychological horror, showing how Gothic conventions have evolved but continue to probe moral and societal anxieties.]

Gothic Writing – Orals

Topic: Representation of gender

Pathway: How does Gothic literature construct masculinity as a source of danger?

Key Terms:

Hubris
Liminality
Intertextuality
Male Gaze
Objectification
Patriarchal power
Symbolism
Psychological control

Quotes/References:

"In one long yellow string I wound
Three times her little throat around, And
strangled her. No pain felt she; I am quite
sure she felt no pain." **I.1**
"He stripped me, gourmand that he was, as
if he were stripping the leaves off an
artichoke... And so my purchaser
unwrapped his bargain." **I.2**
"my father lost me to The Beast at cards" **I.3**

"the child of his desire" **II.1**
"What big teeth you have!... All the better to
eat you with." **II.2**
"If I cannot inspire love, I will cause fear!" **II.3**

Plan:

I. Men as source of control

- I.1** Porphorya's lover
- I.2** The Bloody Chamber
- I.3** The Tiger's Bride

II. Men as source of threat or destruction

- I.1** The Snow child
- II.2** The Company of wolves
- II.3** The Creature

Conclusion [These texts show that men in Gothic literature are both controlling and destructive, highlighting the dangerous and oppressive aspects of masculinity.]

Opening [This invites reflection on how Gothic portrayals of destructive masculinity resonate with modern discussions of toxic masculinity in society and culture.]

Gothic Writing – Orals

Topic: Heroes and Villains

Pathway: Ambiguity of morality: Gothic figures who blur the line between hero and villain

Key Terms:

Liminality
Ambiguity
Hybridity
Intertextuality
Subjectivity
Inner thought
Morality
Symbolism
Doppelganger
Empathy

Quotes/References:

"That moment she was mine, mine, fair, /
Perfectly pure and good." **I.1**

"I sensed in myself a potentiality for
corruption that took my breath away." **I.2**

"She is both death and the maiden." **I.3**

"Nothing about her is human except that
she is not a wolf." **II.1**

"The wolf let out a gulp, almost a sob." **II.2**

"I was benevolent and good; misery made
me a fiend." **II.3**

Plan:

I. Ambiguity created through desire and transgression

I.1 Porphorya's lover

I.2 The Bloody Chamber

I.3 The Lady of the House of Love

II. Ambiguity created through victimhood and monstrosity

II.1 Wolf Alice

II.2 The Werewolf

II.3 Frankenstein

Conclusion [Gothic literature destabilizes moral categories, showing that heroes and villains are often not only one or the other.]

Opening [This ambiguity also appears in modern media, e.g., antiheroes in TV series like Breaking Bad or films like Joker, reflecting contemporary fascination with moral complexity.]

Gothic Writing – Orals

Topic: The role of the Supernatural

Pathway: How the supernatural in Gothic writing reflects modern fears and opposition to societal enclosing norms?

Key Terms:

Supernatural / Fantastic
Subversion of social norms
Female agency
Symbolism
Transformation
Otherness
Fear
Imagery
Liminality
Intertextuality
Contrast

Quotes/References:

"Alone and palely loitering." **I.1**

"I knew from the first moment I saw him how the Erl-King would do me grievous harm." **I.2**

"I saw the dull yellow eye of the creature open; it breathed hard, and a convulsive motion agitated its limbs." **I.3**

"I knew he could tear me apart and yet I was not afraid." **II.1**

"She knew she was nobody's meat." **II.2**

"The Lion looked at her with a soft and melancholy gaze, and she felt the castle open to her." **II.3**

Plan:

I. The Supernatural as a source of personal / psychological fear

I.1 La Belle Dame Sans Merci

I.2 The Erl-King

I.3 Frankenstein

II. The supernatural as an opposition to limiting societal norms

II.1 The Tiger's Bride

II.2 The Company of Wolves

II.3 The Courtship of Mr Lyon

Conclusion [In Gothic literature, the supernatural can both reveal personal fears and psychological tensions (Axe1) and challenge societal norms and expectations (Axe2), allowing readers to explore how characters confront both internal anxieties and external pressures, which raises the question of how the supernatural reflects and critiques human experience.]

Opening [The supernatural as a means to explore fears and societal norms is not limited to Gothic literature: we can also see it in modern horror films, such as Jordan Peele's *Get Out*, or in contemporary fantasy novels like Neil Gaiman's *Coraline*, where supernatural elements expose personal anxieties and societal pressures, highlighting that these themes remain relevant across different media and periods.]

Gothic Writing – Orals

Topic: The use and effect of setting

Pathway: How Gothic setting create power dynamics between characters ?

Key Terms:

Power Dynamics
Entrapment
Isolation
Domination / Oppression
Vulnerability
Claustrophobic Setting
Pathetic Fallacy
Atmospheric Tension
Liminality
Psychological Imprisonment
The Uncanny
Intertextuality

Quotes/References:

"It was now very late and the castle was adrift, as far as it could go from the land, in the middle of the silent ocean[...]" **I.1**
""The woods enclose and then enclose again" **I.2**

"Unlifted was the clinking latch" + "I am aweary, aweary" **II.1**
"The sedge has wither'd from the lake, / And no birds sing" + "Alone and palely loitering" **II.2**

Plan:

I. Isolated Gothic setting give physical power to dominant figures

I.1 The Bloody Chamber

I.2 The Erl-King

II. Gothic settings create psychological domination through atmosphere

II.1 Mariana

II.2 La Belle Dame Sans Merci

Conclusion [Gothic settings are not merely backdrops but active forces that shape power relationships, trapping characters physically and psychologically.]

Opening [Similarly, in Rebecca, the imposing setting of Manderley reinforces power imbalance and psychological oppression, showing the continued importance of setting in Gothic narratives.]

Gothic Writing – Orals

Topic: The monster and the monstrous

Pathway: How do Gothic monsters blur boundaries (human/inhuman, civilized/savage), challenging the idea of fixed identity?

Key Terms:

Hybridity
Otherness
Ambiguity
Liminality
Intertextuality
Transgression
Symbolism
Narrative Perspective
Doppelgänger
Pathetic Fallacy
Metamorphosis/Transformation
Monstrous
Subversion of genre
Moral Relativism

Quotes/References:

"I am alone and miserable: man will not associate with me; but one as deformed and horrible as myself would not deny herself to me." **I.1**

"I ought to be thy Adam, but I am rather the fallen angel..." **I.2**

"I was benevolent and good; misery made me a fiend." **I.3**

"And each stroke of his tongue ripped off skin after successive skin, all the skins of a life in the world, and left behind a nascent patina of shining hairs." **II.1**

"The wolves had tended her because they knew she was an imperfect wolf[...]" **II.2**

She has the mysterious solitude of ambiguous states; she

hovers in a no-man's land between life and death, sleeping and waking[...]" **II.3**

Plan:

I. Frankenstein: the monster as a boundary between human and inhuman

I.1 The creature human's like emotions

I.2 The Creature's intellectual development

I.3 The Creature as a mirror of society

II. Angela Carter: monsters as hybrid, ambiguous beings

II.1 Tiger's Bride

II.2 Wolf Alice

II.3 The Lady of the House of Lovd

Conclusion [Gothic monsters reveal that identity is fluid, socially constructed, and morally complex rather than fixed or innate.]

Opening [This idea of liminality and hybrid identity can also be explored in Kafka's Metamorphosis or Victorian vampire fiction, where transformation and otherness challenge human self-perception.]

Gothic Writing – Orals

Topic: Melodrama and Realism

Pathway: How does Gothic literature use heightened emotional experiences to blur the line between melodrama and realism?

Key Terms:

Gothic Tropes
Liminality
Intertextuality
Narrative Voice/Focalization
Symbolism
Psychological Realism
Melodramatic Exaggeration
Imagery
Foreshadowing
Metaphor/Allegory

Quotes/References:

"I am alone and miserable: man will not associate with me; but one as deformed and horrible as myself would not deny herself to me." **I.1**

"I considered the being whom I had cast among mankind... he was benevolent and good; misery made him a fiend." **I.2**

"Wearing an antique bridal gown, the beautiful queen of the vampires sits all alone in her dark, high house under the eyes of the portraits of her demented and atrocious ancestors[...]" **II.1**

"Poor, wounded thing... locked half and half between such strange states..., howls like a wolf with his foot in a trap or a woman in labour, and bleeds." **II.2**

Plan:

I. Emotional suffering and isolation

I.1 Frankenstein

I.2 Frankenstein

II. Gothic and heightened emotional imagery

II.1 The Lady of The House of Love

II.2 Wolf-Alice

Conclusion [In both Frankenstein and Carter's stories, heightened emotional experiences allow characters to exist in extremes, blurring the boundary between melodrama and realism, showing how intense emotions reveal universal human truths.]

Opening [This exploration of emotional intensity and blurred boundaries could also be extended to Gothic poetry, such as the works of Keats or Shelley, where heightened feelings similarly mix the dramatic and the psychologically real.]

Pathway: Can the powerless become threatening in Gothic literature?

Key Terms:

Liminality
Intertextuality
The Uncanny
Grotesque
Sublime
Otherness / Monstruosity
Patriarchy
Narrative Voice
Transformation Motif
Gothic Doubling
Psychological Entrapment

Quotes/References:

"I was benevolent and good; misery made me a fiend." **I.1**

"I knew from the first moment I saw him how Erl-King would do me grievous harm." **I.2**

"If I cannot inspire love, I will cause fear." **II.1**

"That moment she was mine, mine, fair." **II.2**

"I shrugged the drops off my beautiful fur." **III.1**

"The brain has corridors surpassing material place." **III.2**

Plan:

I. The powerless as victims of domination

I.1 Frankenstein

I.2 The Erl-King

II. The transformation: from victim to menace

II.1 Frankenstein

II.2 Porphorya's Lover

III. Menace as a new form of power

III.1 The Tiger's Bride

III.2 One Need Not Be A Chamber To Be Haunted

Conclusion + Opening [Power and menace are deeply intertwined in Gothic literature, as the powerless can become threatening through transformation, which can be further explored in dystopian fiction where fear is also used as a tool of control.]